

Week 6B Lit Example Reader

EITHER/OR AND IF/THEN IN CAESAR AND MACBETH

Purpose: Literary passages for Week 6B: test compound pressure—either/or alternatives and if/then conditions—without treating persuasion as proof.

What to watch for: What options are offered? What condition is assumed? What follows if the compound claim is granted? What remains unproved?

Before the Passages: The Week 6B Logic Tools

- **Either/or:** alternatives offered as if they settle a choice.
- **False choice:** an either/or that ignores other live options.
- **If/then:** a condition linked to a result (antecedent → consequent).
- **Valid moves:** grant the if-part to get the then-part; deny the then-part to reject the if-part.
- **Traps:** treating the then-part as proof of the if-part; treating denial of the if-part as proof that the then-part fails.
- **Form vs fact:** even a clean compound pattern fails if a premise is false, loaded, or unproved.

Passage 1: Excerpts from *Julius Caesar*, Act 3, Scene 2 — Brutus's Either/Or

Context: After Caesar's death, Brutus addresses the Roman crowd. Watch how he frames the choice between Caesar living and the people living free.

Brutus. If there be any in this assembly, any dear friend of Caesar's, to him I say that Brutus' love to Caesar was no less than his. If then that friend demand why Brutus rose against Caesar, this is my answer:—Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more. Had you rather Caesar were living and die all slaves, than that Caesar were dead, to live all free men? As Caesar loved me, I weep for him; as he was fortunate, I rejoice at it; as he was valiant, I honour him: but, as he was ambitious, I slew him. There is tears for his love; joy for his fortune; honour for his valour; and death for his ambition.

Reader Notes

Here is your most assisted example. Brutus pairs love of Caesar with love of Rome, then presses a hard alternative: Caesar living with the people as slaves, or Caesar dead with the people free. The speech can feel finished because the either/or is vivid and moral. A disciplined listener still separates several jobs: (1) what either/or is being offered; (2) whether those two options really exhaust the live possibilities; (3) whether words such as *slave*, *free*, and *ambitious* have been fixed; and (4) whether ambition has been proved, not merely asserted. Compound form can create pressure even before the fact test is passed.

Reading task: Underline the either/or question. Circle *slaves*, *free*, and *ambitious*. In the margin, write one other live option a careful Roman might still want considered.

Passage 2: Excerpts from *Macbeth*, Act 1, Scenes 3 and 5 — Conditional Prophecy Pressure

Context: The weird sisters greet Macbeth with titles he has not yet fully secured. Later Lady Macbeth receives news of the prophecy. Watch if/then pressure: what is treated as condition, and what is treated as already proved.

First Witch. All hail, Macbeth! hail to thee, thane of Glamis!

Second Witch. All hail, Macbeth, hail to thee, thane of Cawdor!

Third Witch. All hail, Macbeth, thou shalt be king hereafter!

Macbeth. (*aside*) Glamis, and thane of Cawdor!

The greatest is behind.

Lady Macbeth. Glamis thou art, and Cawdor; and shalt be

What thou art promised: yet do I fear thy nature;

It is too full o' the milk of human kindness

To catch the nearest way: thou wouldst be great;

Art not without ambition, but without

The illness should attend it...

Hie thee hither,

That I may pour my spirits in thine ear;

And chastise with the valour of my tongue

All that impedes thee from the golden round.

Reader Notes

This passage shifts more work to you. Notice how later certainty grows from earlier greeting and promise. A listener can reconstruct pressures such as: if the sisters speak truly, then kingship is ahead; if Cawdor has come true, then the greater promise is nearer; if the crown is promised, then hesitation is waste. Mark where a condition is treated as if it were already proof. Decide whether a fulfilled smaller title proves the larger destiny, or only makes a conditional hope feel stronger.

Reading task: Star any line that functions like an if/then. In the margin, note one place where a later fact might be used as if it proved an earlier prophecy. Do not yet write the full worksheet diagnosis; gather evidence only.